

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

MONDAY · 6 JULY 2026 · THE WEEKDAY BRIEFING



THE SIGNAL ARRIVES LATE

THE WORLD

One signature, two clocks:
the Iran deal's 60-day
countdown ticks in Doha

SINGAPORE & MACRO

The war reaches your meter:
July's +17% power tariff is a
bill posted in arrears

CURIOSITIES

The ten-year movie begins:
Vera Rubin starts filming the
whole southern sky

INSIDE THIS EDITION

TWELVE DESKS · ONE WORLD

The bill comes due late

Every cause keeps its consequence waiting. This issue reads the lag — the tariff posted in arrears, the print that measures a month already gone, the muscle banked at forty-five, the light that left its star before the pharaohs.

THE DESKS

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"The Long Fuse" — light, interest, policy, and a July in 1914

FROM THE DESK

"Though the mills of God grind slowly, yet they grind exceeding small; / Though with patience He stands waiting, with exactness grinds He all."

— Henry Wadsworth Longfellow, *"Retribution" (1845)*, his rendering of Friedrich von Logau's *Sinngedichte (1654)* — a couplet whose thought runs back to Plutarch's essay *On the Delay of Divine Justice*.

Our epigraph for an issue about lag. The line survives because it holds two truths at once: reckoning is *slow* — it keeps you waiting — and it is *exact*. That is also a fair description of a CPI print, an electricity tariff, a telescope, and a set of dumbbells. The bill is late; it is not wrong.

THE STRIP — AT THU 2 JUL CLOSE

INSTRUMENT	LEVEL	NOTE
STI	5,244	record 3 Jul
VWRA	~\$190	near ATH
S&P 500	~7,500	broad bid
US 10Y	4.49%	steady
JGB 10Y	2.77%	multi-decade high
USD/SGD	1.292	SGD soft
USD/JPY	~¥160	weak yen
Brent	~\$71	war premium gone
Gold	~\$4,170	off Jan ATH
BTC	~\$61k	high-vol read

Dated levels, held honestly (US markets shut Fri 3 Jul for the Independence Day observance). Macro Desk, p15. Market data is explanation, not advice.

THE WORLD · IRAN & THE GULF

One signature, two clocks

Three weeks after the memorandum was signed, two timers run in parallel — a 60-day diplomatic countdown in Switzerland, and the slow, grudging clock of a strait learning to carry ships again. Neither is keeping the other's time.

The war that began on 28 February has, for now, stopped shooting; what it has not done is end. The interim memorandum signed on 17–18 June started a 60-day window — "extendable with mutual consent"¹ — inside which Washington and Tehran are meant to convert a ceasefire into a settlement on enrichment, sanctions and the Strait of Hormuz. On 1 July, mediators Qatar and Pakistan hosted the parties in Doha; Vice-President Vance called the talks "going well," and the two sides agreed a "roadmap" and a deconfliction line for the strait after marathon sessions at Bürgenstock.²

The diplomatic clock, then, is ticking — but not loudly. A Council on Foreign Relations analyst put the odds of a full deal inside 60 days at roughly nil; the hard questions (the fate of some 441 kg of 60%-enriched uranium last verified a year ago, the return of IAEA inspectors to bombed sites, whether Iran may levy "services" fees on the strait) are exactly the ones the memorandum deferred.³ Tehran insists inspections wait for a final accord; Washington says they are coming, "no rush." The words are the news; the substance is on layaway.

The second clock is mechanical, and slower still. Roughly 35 commercial vessels a day are now transiting Hormuz — about a third of the ~110/day peacetime norm — with the central channel still holding an estimated 80 uncleared mines and traffic threading the Omani south and Iranian north routes.⁴ The GPS spoofing that scrambled ships' positions for months has eased; an IRGC warning against "unauthorised" crossings has not. One container vessel ran aground last week after skipping Tehran's approved lane. Brent, which spent the spring pricing a closed strait, now sits in the low \$70s — the war premium fully drained. That, too, is a clock: the oil market has already decided the worst is behind it (see Macro, p15). The households paying June's gas bills in July have not (see Singapore, p5).

The words are the news; the substance is on layaway.

What links the two timers is a single wager: that a paper promise, given time, hardens into a fact. Sometimes it does. The danger of a 60-day fuse is that the things it defers — enrichment, inspection, the toll — are precisely the things that can relight it.

FOUR CAPITALS, ONE MEMORANDUM

WASHINGTON	CBS / STATE DEPT.	TEHRAN	IRIB / TASNIM
Rubio, touring the Gulf: an "international waterway — no country charges tolls." Trump says inspectors will go, "no rush". Vance frames the goal as removing the enriched stockpile. Progress is asserted; the timeline is left soft.		Ghalibaf: the strait "will never return to its pre-war conditions and stays under Iranian administration with Oman. Baghaei: inspections only within a final deal. The framing is sovereignty regained, oil flowing again (~40M bbl sold since the waiver).	
SOURCES: 1–3 CNN live (11 Jun 2026); Wikipedia: "2025–26 Iran–U.S. negotiations" (upd. 4 Jul); 4 BBC; 5 Al Jazeera (24 Jun); 6 Reuters (23 Jun); 7 CBS News; 8 Al Jazeera (24 Jun); 9 IAEA statements via CBS; 10 Spectrum News (24 Jun 2026).		MERIDIAN · THE WORLD	
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~35

VESSELS/DAY THROUGH HORMUZ — $\approx \frac{1}{3}$ OF THE PRE-WAR ~110

60

DAYS TO A FINAL DEAL (FROM ~18 JUN; EXTENDABLE)

441kg

60%-HEU — LAST IAEA-VERIFIED, ~JUN 2025

THE SCEPTIC

"There is no way Washington and Tehran finish this in sixty days," CFR's Charles Kupchan told Al Jazeera. The memorandum's genius — deferring the hard parts — is also its fragility.⁵

THE WORLD · THE OTHER PARTY

A birthday, and a distraction the country needed

America turned 250 this weekend. The bigger event was played on grass.

The United States marked its semiquincentennial on 4 July with the usual fireworks and an unusual co-host: a World Cup it is staging with Canada and Mexico, now deep into its knockout rounds.¹ FIFA's Gianni Infantino had pitched the tournament, back in 2024, as a party to enhance the anniversary. Instead — as CNN's analysis put it — the football stood in gentle contrast to it: a common cause in a country short of them, its stadiums and fan zones packed by visitors discovering an America "more subtle and complex than its bitter political caricature."²

The bracket has been kind to the drama. The three hosts all advanced from the group stage; today (6 July) delivers a heavyweight Round-of-16 double — Portugal v Spain in Arlington, and the USMNT against Belgium in Seattle — before quarter-finals that could put France against Morocco and Brazil into the last eight.³ Iran went home without a win but not without

honour, its 1–1 draw with Egypt undone by a VAR flag; ESPN's "remarkable" epitaph drew a predictable ratio. The final is 19 July at MetLife.

For a Singapore reader the tournament is a late-night proposition — kick-offs land in the small hours here — which is its own small story on the Family Desk (p13). For everyone else it is the summer's most reliable escape: ninety minutes in which, as Infantino likes to say, the person from the other part of the world turns out not to be so bad after all.

THE CHATTER

On the ground, the viral clips write themselves — Scotland's Tartan Army drinking Boston dry, a mobbed Fenway, whole downtowns "buzzing like it's pre-pandemic." The knock on 2026 — over-commercialisation, ticket prices — hasn't gone away; it's just been out-shouted by the noise of the crowd.

— CNN; social-media roundups, 1–4 Jul 2026

IN BRIEF — THE WIRE THAT DIDN'T LEAD

Lebanon. The Israel–Hezbollah ceasefire, folded into the Iran memorandum, keeps fraying: tit-for-tat strikes have continued in the south even as the deconfliction line stands up. Iran calls a violation of the truce a threat to "the memorandum as a whole." Developing.

Ukraine. Long-range strikes on Russian refining capacity continue; the front is static, the energy war is not. A one-line continuity, not a re-explainer.

Colombia. The presidential race stays a two-horse contest — de la Espriella narrowly ahead of Cepeda — with a runoff the likely outcome. Carried from No. 31.

The dollar's quiet retreat. The 13-month-high DXY of late June has softened to ~101 as the US hike scare fades (Macro, p15) — a geopolitical fact as much as a monetary one, easing pressure on emerging-market currencies including the rupee and rupiah.

Oil's peace dividend. Brent in the low \$70s is the clearest market verdict that the Gulf war is, for now, over — good news everywhere except the July electricity bill it is too late to un-write (Singapore, p5).

The stranded fleet. The IMO/Oman corridor is still evacuating the ~11,000 seafarers marooned in the Gulf during the closure — a humanitarian tail that outlasts the headlines.

"You realise this other person, from this other part of the world — he's not so bad as described." — Gianni Infantino

SINGAPORE • COST OF LIVING

The war reaches your meter

Oil has collapsed; the strait is reopening; the Gulf is, for now, quiet. And on 1 July, Singapore's electricity tariff jumped 17 per cent. Both things are true — because the bill for a war arrives months after the shooting stops.

From 1 July to 30 September, the regulated household tariff rose 4.64 cents to 31.91 cents per kWh before GST — 34.78 cents with it — a 17.0 per cent increase, the sharpest in years.¹ For a family in a four-room HDB flat, SP Group put the extra at S\$17.14 a month before tax. The cause is not this week's news but last quarter's: the tariff's energy component is set from average gas prices over the first two-and-a-half months of the preceding quarter — here, 1 April to 15 June, the most war-inflated window there was.²

That is the cruelty of a lag. Singapore imports about 95 per cent of its electricity fuel as gas, and gas prices trail oil, and the tariff trails gas. So the July bill is denominated in a war that markets have already moved past: Brent is back in the low \$70s, the Hormuz premium drained (see The World, p5-adjacent). The relief is real — but it will not reach the meter until the fourth quarter at the earliest, "possibly Q1 2027," on the EMA's own account.³ You are paying, in July, for June; you will be repaid, if at all, near Christmas.

For most HDB households the blow is cushioned. July's GST Voucher — U-Save credited up to S\$190 (double the regular quarter) to more than a million homes, part of up to S\$570 in regular U-Save across FY2026 plus S&CC rebates.⁴ But the rebate is precisely targeted — and a household whose members own more than one property is not eligible. The multiple-home owner, in other words, meets the full increase undiluted: a small, pointed reminder that in Singapore the cost of living is progressive by design.

You are paying, in July, for June; you will be repaid, if at all, near Christmas.

The policy answer is the boring one — the tariff is set by events you cannot control, so control the part you can: consumption, and, for the migrator, local automation of the aircon and lights (Connected Home, p10). The macro answer is patience. The lag that hurts you now will, mechanically, help you later.

ALSO ON THE ISLAND

A record index, a soft dollar. The STI printed a fresh high of 5,244.29 on 3 July (+30.8% YoY), still driven by its bank-and-REIT core and still decoupled from Wall Street's AI wobble — even as the SGD sits near a 2026 weak point around 1.292 to the dollar. A strong index is not a strong currency; the two read different clocks. (Macro, p15.)

The economy, mid-year. MTI holds 2026 growth at 2.0–4.0% after a punchy 6.0% Q1, with downside risk still flagged from the Gulf; NODX momentum is cooling from its AI-server-rush highs toward low-single-digit 2026 growth. The 1 July retirement-age and CPF changes (No. 32/35) are now in force — a one-line continuity, not a re-explainer.

SOURCES • 1–3 SP Group tariff notice & EMA (30 Jun 2026); Sunollo analysis (Jun 2026). 4 Ministry of Finance, U-Save/S&CC (3 Jul 2026). 5 Sunollo; forum roundups. STI: TradingView/SGX (3 Jul). MTI/SingStat (Q1 2026).

NEW REGULATED TARIFF
34.78¢/kWh w/GST
QUARTER-ON-QUARTER
+17.0%
4-ROOM HDB BILL
+\$17.14/mo

THE CHATTER

"A strange fact about living here in 2026: the price to run your air-con this July was effectively decided by a war fought 8,000 km away." The forums split between fatalism and solar quotes — the latter a hedge on the trend, useless against this single quarter.⁵

— local energy commentary;
HardwareZone / Reddit
r/singapore

95%

OF SG ELECTRICITY FUEL IS IMPORTED
GAS

PROPERTY · SUPPLY

A second city, tendered

The URA has put a 3.72-hectare white site in the Jurong Lake District on the market. It will not house a soul for years — which is exactly the point. Supply is the longest fuse in property.

On 3 July the Urban Redevelopment Authority launched the tender for a 3.72-hectare "white site" at Town Hall Link, the largest developable parcel yet released in the Jurong Lake District — Singapore's long-planned second Central Business District.¹ A white site lets the winning developer mix offices, homes, retail and hotel more or less as the market dictates; here it anchors a precinct the state has been assembling for a decade and will keep assembling for another. Nobody will collect rent from it soon. Its influence on prices, though, begins the day it is awarded.

That is the property market's version of this issue's theme. A Government Land Sales parcel is a bet placed years before it pays: the confirmed-list pipeline for 2026 has swollen toward ~9,300 private units, and it is that forward supply — not this week's SORA fixing — that will govern where prices sit in 2029.² The editor's standing rule holds: rates are saturated; supply, launches and policy are the story. JLD is supply with a capital S — a whole downtown willed into being on a multi-year fuse, meant to pull demand (and one day, jobs) west.

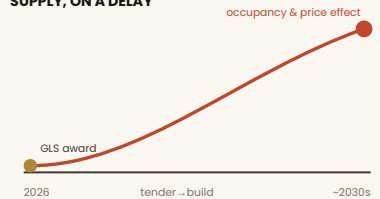
The demand side, meanwhile, is still deep. June's BTO exercise drew 22,312 applications for its five-town tranche, with one project the runaway favourite among singles — evidence that the public queue has not thinned even as private developer sales stay subdued (447 units in May, a three-month low).³ Add the Greater Sentosa master plan, unveiled the same week — merging Sentosa and Pulau Brani into a single resort island, with a new tram and reforested spine — and the through-line is clear: Singapore is planting several districts at once, none of which flowers this year.⁴

A whole downtown willed into being on a multi-year fuse.

For an owner, the read is neither urgency nor complacency. The CCR-and-landed "flight to the top" that showed up in the Q2 flash (No. 35) is a near-term signal; the JLD tender is a decade-term one. Both matter; they simply come due on different calendars.

Rates, in one line. Three-month compounded SORA sits near ~1%, and the softening US rate path (Macro, p15) points to stable-to-easier mortgage costs — but per the standing rule it is a footnote, not a headline. The market's direction is being set by land and launches, not by the fixing.

SUPPLY, ON A DELAY



A land sale is a bet placed years before it pays. Meridian original.

22,312

APPLICATIONS, JUNE BTO (5 TOWNS)

THE SCEPTIC

A caution on second-CBD euphoria: JLD has been "the next big thing" since the 2010s, and white-site flexibility cuts both ways — it can also sit half-built if the office demand it assumes never migrates west. Supply is a fuse; some fuses are damp.

TECHNOLOGY · CHIPS

The memory cycle goes public

This week, the world's most important memory-maker becomes something a small investor can hold. SK hynix's ~US\$29bn Nasdaq debut is the AI supercycle asking the public to co-sign its bet on the future.

Trading in SK hynix's American depositary receipts is expected to begin around 10 July — a US\$29.4-billion offering (₩45.45 trillion) that ranks among the five largest share sales in history.¹ We flagged the filing at its confidential stage (No. 34); the listing itself is the new fact. It matters less as a capital raise than as a threshold: the single most concentrated node in the AI supply chain — the firm that supplies an estimated 57–62 per cent of the world's high-bandwidth memory, and 60–70 per cent of the HBM4 allocated to Nvidia's coming Vera Rubin platform — is now a stock a Singapore reader can buy before breakfast.²

The scale of the dependency is the story. By one 2026 estimate, roughly 70 per cent of all memory chips produced this year will go into AI data centres, leaving other uses to fight over the scraps; building a gigabyte of HBM consumes about four times the wafer capacity of ordinary DRAM.³ Three firms — SK hynix, Micron, Samsung — control the supply, and by engineering scarcity they have escaped the commodity trap that punished memory for decades, posting 60–70 per cent gross margins. In June, Nvidia and SK hynix signed a multi-year pact to co-design future memory, not merely supply it: the customer and the vendor now share a drawing board.⁴

Here is the lag. All of this is compute committed now against demand that arrives later — fabs, HBM lines and Indiana plants financed against an AI build-out whose returns are, politely, still forecast. That is the bull case (real, contracted, sold-out demand through 2027) and the bear case (a circular loop of Nvidia, OpenAI and the hyperscalers financing one another) in a single sentence. The listing lets the public take a side.

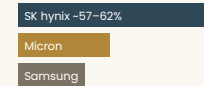
The customer and the vendor now share a drawing board.

The sovereignty reading — this desk's standing lens — is that compute has become a strategic, state-adjacent commodity, allocated by an oligopoly and courted by governments (see the mooted US stake in OpenAI, carried below). The quiet consolation for the index investor: you already own the cycle. VWRA's tech weighting means a Singapore portfolio has been long this supercycle all along — no ADR required.

WHERE THE MEMORY GOES, 2026



HBM SHARE (approx.)



Illustrative shares; industry estimates, 2026.

Scarcity, engineered. Sources: Motley Fool, Omdia estimates (2026).

\$29.4bn

SK HYNIX NASDAQ ADR — A TOP-5 LISTING EVER

DELTA — THE STATE MOVES IN

The mooted ~5% US-government stake in OpenAI (No. 35) is still conceptual and needs Congress; Anthropic, Google and Meta have not signed on. One-line continuity — no re-explainer. The H200-to-China licence question stays a one-line watch.

TECHNOLOGY · RUN IT YOURSELF

The listing lands on your motherboard

The same HBM boom that makes SK hynix a \$29bn IPO is why the RAM in your next build costs twice what it did. The home-labber's household "memory tax" is the retail end of a datacentre order book placed a year ago.

There is a straight line from the trading floor to your desktop. Because the memory giants have pre-allocated nearly all their 2026 capacity to high-bandwidth memory for AI (see p7), the ordinary DRAM that goes into consumer PCs has gone scarce and dear — consumer RAM up on the order of 100 per cent off the lows, the cheapest 32GB DDR5 kits pushing past US\$370, with Crucial's retail line retired and the bulk of new capacity diverted to HBM.¹ That is the "memory tax" (No. 24) at full stretch. And it is, precisely, a lag: today's living-room prices are last year's hyperscaler commitments finally reaching the checkout.

You cannot fight the tape, so the home-lab strategy is subtraction, not accumulation. First, **run small**. The open-weight field has quietly made a 24GB card enough: Qwen 3.6-35B-A3B remains the standout single-consumer-GPU frontier pick, with Gemma 4 (12B fits 16GB) and DeepSeek V4-Flash making a 16-32GB box genuinely useful for real work.² The June tooling — Ollama's MLX engine, LM Studio's KV-cache checkpointing — reclaims memory rather than demanding more. Second, **buy the RAM inside the**

box: unified-memory mini-PCs (Strix Halo-class) put 70B-class models within reach without paying spot DRAM prices per stick. Third, **shift DRAM to VRAM** where a used 24GB card still runs a 30B model at 4-bit.

THE CHATTER — R/LOCALLLAMA

"Own the weights, rent the watts" is the mood. The consolation nobody says out loud: a memory glut, if the AI-capex bet ever unwinds (Macro, p15), eventually flows the other way — the same lag that taxed your build could one day refund it. Don't hold your breath; do hold your upgrade.

The through-line with p7 is the whole issue in miniature. A bet placed in a boardroom in 2025 arrives, in 2026, as a line on your parts list — and the discipline, at both ends of the wire, is to build for the workload you actually have, not the one the marketing promises.

THE SCEPTIC

Benchmarks still flatter. A 35B model that dazzles on a leaderboard can crawl on your box once context fills and the KV cache balloons — the tax you don't see on the spec sheet. Measure tokens-per-second on your hardware before you believe the chart.

THE KIT · AUDIO

The battery you can change

Sennheiser's new flagship headphone hides a small quiet radicalism behind the earcup: a battery you can replace with a Phillips screwdriver. In a category built on planned death, that is the most interesting spec on the sheet.

We first noted the Momentum 5 Wireless on the shelf back in No. 31; the reviews have now landed, and the verdict is warm.¹ What Hi-Fi awarded five stars for a sound it called "rich, smooth and refined," with a "beautifully expressive" midrange, Dolby Atmos head-tracking, and up to ~57 hours of ANC playback on the same 42mm transducers as before but a smarter processor and mic array.² All of that is table stakes at the price. The genuinely new thing is the screw.

Wireless headphones have been, for a decade, disposable objects with a two-to-three-year lifespan set by a glued-in lithium cell. Sennheiser has made the Momentum 5's battery user-replaceable — a deliberate bet, nudged along by the EU's push toward serviceable batteries, that a premium object should outlast its first cell.³ This is the lag in a consumer good: you pay a little now (a slightly thicker cup, a fiddlier design) for a return that arrives in year four, when the thing you'd otherwise have binned is still playing. Repairability is deferred value — the same argument as an index fund, in plastic and copper.

In a category built on planned death, that is the most interesting spec on the sheet.

For the reader who buys once and keeps — the same instinct behind a serviceable mechanical watch (Good Life, p11) — this is the more meaningful "flagship" than any new driver. The best gear is not the gear that wins this year's shoot-out; it's the gear you're still wearing when the shoot-out is forgotten.

STILL ON THE SHELF

Sony WH-1000X "The ColleXion" — the 10th-anniversary luxe XM6 (leather & metal, ~\$650); reviewers rate the aesthetics above the ANC gain. One-line, from No. 35.

Garmin Forerunner 70 / 170 — the full physio stack at the entry tier, now reviewed and closed (No. 32); **Soundcore Liberty 5 Pro Max** and the **Shanling EC Play** "new Discman" carry as value/quirk picks with no fresh peg.

THE SCEPTIC

Replaceable is not the same as easy — you still need a screwdriver, a spare cell, and the nerve to open a \$400 object — and plenty of glued-shut rivals (Sony, Bose) still sound superb. Repairability is a reason to buy, not a substitute for tuning. Judge the sound first.

~57h

ANC PLAYBACK — AND A BATTERY YOU CAN SWAP

ALSO SHIPPING — FOR THE SCI-FI SHELF

Xreal's R1 AR glasses begin shipping this month at ~US\$850 — a "monitor for your face" with a high-refresh OLED that early testers found sharp and immersive, marred only by some edge screen-tearing a firmware update should fix. The Blade Runner future keeps arriving in instalments (No. 31 callback).⁴

CONNECTED HOME · ENERGY

The light switch and the tariff

You can't argue with the July power tariff — it was set by a war and a formula. But the part of the bill you can touch is the part a local smart home was built to touch. This month, that stops being a hobby and starts being a hedge.

Singapore's 17-per-cent tariff jump (p5) is the kind of number that sends people to solar quotes. The faster, cheaper move is the one the migrator already owns the parts for: measure, then trim. Home Assistant's Energy dashboard turns a vague dread into a ranked list — which circuits, which hours, which forgotten always-on device is quietly eating a fifth of the bill. You cannot manage what you cannot see; local telemetry is how you see it, without shipping your consumption habits to a vendor's cloud.

From there the levers are boring and effective, and they lean on the reader's own migration path — Lutron for lighting, Home Assistant as the brain, Matter/Thread underneath. Schedule the aircon to a room's occupancy rather than a clock; pre-cool before the afternoon peak and coast; kill phantom loads on a local automation that never phones home. None of it is glamorous. All of it compounds — a small setup cost now against a saving on every bill for years, which is the same deferred-value trade as a repairable headphone (p9) or a banked VO₂max (p18).

LOCAL-FIRST, AS PRUDENCE

HA 2026.7 shipped on 1 July (No. 35): purpose/intent automations are now the default editor, and native diagnostic sensors answer "why did my plug disappear?" locally. The point isn't novelty — it's that the system keeping your energy data (and your evening routine) doesn't depend on a subscription that can be retired out from under you.¹

The lag reading is exact. The tariff is a bill posted in arrears; the smart home is a hedge posted in advance — a bit of wiring and YAML now that pays out quietly across every quarter the formula turns against you. You can't move the strait. You can move the setpoint.

THE SCEPTIC

Don't oversell the dashboard. The single biggest lever on a Singapore bill is still the aircon setpoint and how long it runs — a degree and a timer beat any automation graph. Smart-home savings are real but marginal; treat them as the trim, not the fix. And a Matter logo on a plug is still not proof of a clean local join (No. 31).

SOURCES · 1 Home Assistant 2026.7 release notes (1 Jul 2026); No. 35 (carried). Energy-dashboard & local-control features per HA documentation. Savings are household-dependent; figures illustrative, not guaranteed.

THE GOOD LIFE · THE OBJECT

Warmth, on a delay

Astell&Kern has put four vacuum tubes inside a pocket music player. It is gloriously unnecessary, faintly absurd — and it makes the case for the whole issue, because a tube is a thing that only works once it has waited.

The SP4000T is the next evolution of Astell&Kern's flagship portable player, and its headline upgrade is the least modern component imaginable: a quad set of Raytheon JAN6418 MIL-Spec vacuum tubes — glass valves of a kind that predate the transistor — governed by a "Triple Tube Mode" offering up to 54 combinations of tube and current.¹ Pricing is unannounced but will sit north of the outgoing SP4000's ~US\$4,290. It is, unapologetically, an object for the person who has decided that sound is worth carrying weight for.

Why it belongs in an issue about lag: a tube does not work the instant you switch it on. It has to warm — the cathode heats, the valve settles, and only then does the famous "tube warmth" arrive. Every audiophile knows the ritual of waiting for a valve amp to come up to temperature before the music sounds right. It is the friendliest possible metaphor for the whole book: the good stuff comes on a delay, and the delay is the point, not a defect. In a season when everything else in this reader's life optimises for instant (the local model that must fit, the tariff that arrives too fast), a device that insists on warming up first is a small act of resistance.²

The good stuff comes on a delay, and the delay is the point.

It is also, like the repairable headphone (p9), an object built to be owned rather than cycled — heavy, serviceable, indifferent to next year's launch. That is the Good Life thesis in one sentence: buy few things, buy things that wait for you, keep them.

THE ESCAPE — ONE LINE

The soft-yen window holds: USD/JPY around ¥160 keeps Japan the value trip of the year for a Singapore traveller, with the tax-free reform now bedded in. A continuity note, not a re-survey — the Macro Desk (p15) has the currency read; the Diary (p19) has the July matsuri worth flying for.

54

TUBE/CURRENT VOICINGS ON ONE
POCKET PLAYER

THE SCEPTIC

Let's be honest about what this is: a >\$4k luxury for a sound difference most ears meet halfway with a good solid-state DAC and a quiet room. Tubes add euphonic colour, not fidelity. Buy it for the ritual and the warmth, not because the measurements demand it — and they don't.

Grace note. The wired/analog counter-cycle (No. 31) keeps widening — new tube DAPs, CD players, turntables — a whole category betting, correctly, that some pleasures don't compress.

SCREEN & SOUND · MUSIC

The summer of the sequel

July's release calendar is a study in the long return — a Madonna record that answers one she made twenty-one years ago, headlining a month in which pop's biggest names all reach backward to move forward.

Madonna opened the month on 3 July with *Confessions II*, an explicit sequel to 2005's *Confessions on a Dance Floor* and a reunion with that album's architect, producer Stuart Price.¹ Two decades is a long fuse for a follow-up; the lead single "Bring Your Love," with Sabrina Carpenter, arrived in May as the setup. Whatever the reviews settle at, the gesture is the story of the month: the return that takes twenty-one years to land.

She is not alone in reaching back. Ariana Grande closes July (the 31st) with *Petal*, her first proper pop chapter after the *Wicked* detour; Charli xcx follows *Brat* with the deliberately different *Music, Fashion, Film* (24 July); Steve Lacy returns after a long gap with *Oh Yeah?* (17 July); Tyla's *A*POP* pushes "popiano" global (24 July). Even the Rolling Stones' coming *Foreign Tongues* is a kind of homecoming — it carries a final appearance by the late Charlie Watts, recorded before his death.² A whole month of artists arriving, late, at something they set in motion years ago.

DELTA — THE APPOINTED HOUR, MOVED

The Strokes' long-delayed *Reality Awaits* (our recurring watch since No. 25) slipped again — now dated 24 July — reportedly so the streaming and vinyl releases land together. A one-line continuity: the record that keeps rescheduling its own arrival.³ Olivia Rodrigo's next album, due before month-end, stays a one-line note here (saturated).

On screens — the demoted lead. Christopher Nolan's *The Odyssey* (17 July, IMAX 70mm) is the summer's tentpole, its advance demand reportedly outpacing *Oppenheimer* and 70mm pairs reselling for four figures (No. 35). Per our three-lead rule it steps back to a secondary this issue — the peg is still the release, not the result. It heads a healthy summer (2026 domestic box office running up double digits, *Toy Story 5* the year's lone billion-dollar film so far), with *Spider-Man: Brand New Day* (31 July) close behind.⁴

THE SCEPTIC

Reinvention-by-sequel is also a hedge against risk: a known title tests better than a new one. The kind read is homage; the cynical read is that even pop's boldest are, this summer, buying back their own past because the past is pre-sold. Both can be true.

SOURCES · 1 Billboard; EntertainmentNow; DraftKings New Music Friday (3 Jul 2026). 2 InMusic; Ultimate Classic Rock July-2026 previews. 3 EntertainmentNow (Strokes delay); No. 25/28 (carried). 4 Screen Rant; Box Office Pro; Deadline (Jul 2026). No lyrics reproduced.

THE FAMILY DESK • SLEEP

The lever hiding in plain sight

Of all the things a parent can adjust for an eleven-year-old, one is unusually powerful and unusually neglected — because its costs arrive on a delay. Not tonight's tantrum, but next week's grades, mood and friendships. This month, a World Cup is quietly testing it.

Parenting advice tends to chase the visible: screens, marks, tempers. Sleep is the opposite — invisible, undramatic, and disproportionately consequential. A 2026 systematic review of children aged six to twelve gathers what large longitudinal studies keep finding: shorter or more fragmented sleep tracks with diminished attention, weaker memory and academic achievement, and poorer emotional and social functioning — in ordinary, typically developing children, not only clinical ones.¹ Around eleven, the recommended window is roughly nine to eleven hours. Most tweens sit below it, and the deficit is stealthy because a child does not look tired the way an adult does; they look, instead, moody, scattered, or "difficult."

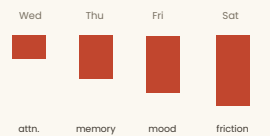
That is the lag. Sleep debt is the household's purest example of a bill posted in arrears: the cost of a late Tuesday is not paid on Tuesday but drawn down across the week — in the frustration tolerance that fails on Thursday, the maths that won't stick on Friday, the friendship that frays over nothing on Saturday. Because the cause and the symptom are days apart, we rarely connect them, and blame the child's character for what is really the child's schedule.

A child does not look tired the way an adult does; they look "difficult."

There is a live experiment running right now. The World Cup (The World, p4) plays into mid-July, and for a Singapore household the good matches kick off in the small hours — a textbook source of what sleep researchers call "social jet-lag," the weekday-to-weekend drift in sleep timing that studies of past tournaments have measured in children directly.² It is a lovely thing to share with a football-loving eleven-year-old. It is also, biologically, a debt — and worth taking on with open eyes.

THE BILL, DRAWN DOWN

late night



Schematic: cost rises across the days after, not the night of.

Cause on Tuesday; consequence all week. Meridian original.

9–11h

RECOMMENDED NIGHTLY SLEEP, AGE ~11

THE CHATTER

Parent forums converge on one hack that survives contact with reality: hold the *wake-up* time steady even when bedtime slips. A consistent morning anchor limits the weekend drift more reliably than policing lights-out — useful in a fortnight of 3 a.m. kick-offs.

THE FAMILY DESK · WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT

Protect the window, not the perfection

The evidence points to a schedule, not a crackdown. Here is what actually moves the needle — and why the panic version of this advice does more harm than the problem.

The mechanism, briefly. Sleep in this age band is when memory consolidates and the emotional thermostat resets; deep sleep does the filing, and the timing matters as much as the total. That is why fragmented or shifted sleep can hurt even when the raw hours look adequate — the same eight hours starting at 1 a.m. is not the same eight hours starting at 9 p.m.¹ This connects to a thread this desk has run all year: the child's environment sets the baseline (No. 32's parental warmth, No. 34's autonomy). Sleep is simply the most measurable, most fixable of those environmental levers.

What actually helps. Consistency beats heroics. Hold a steady wake time — even on weekends, even after a match — and bedtime tends to self-correct within a night or two. Guard the last hour: light, cool room, wind-down, and the phone charging *outside* the bedroom (a boundary about sleep, not about screens as sin — this desk holds screen-time itself to be saturated and over-blamed). And treat the World Cup as a budget: pick the matches worth the debt, watch those together, and let the rest be highlights over breakfast.

TRY THIS — THE FORTNIGHT PLAN

1) Anchor wake-up to one time all week. 2) Choose two or three "worth-it" late matches, not every night. 3) Bank a nap or an early night on the surrounding days — sleep debt can be partly repaid if it isn't allowed to compound. 4) Watch the mood on days two and three, not the night itself; that's when the bill shows.

The honest caveat. The prescription is a rhythm, not a rulebook, and it survives the occasional blowout. One thrilling 3 a.m. quarter-final with your kid is a memory, not a wound.

DON'T BE ALARMIST

A few late nights across a once-in-four-years tournament will not damage a healthy eleven-year-old — childhood is meant to hold a few magic exceptions, and a shared 3 a.m. goal may be worth more than the sleep it costs. What the research warns against is the *chronic* version: a sleep window that quietly shrinks month after month. If short, disrupted sleep persists for weeks alongside a real change in mood, learning or appetite, that is a conversation with a paediatrician — not a reason to panic over one big football summer. The goal is a protected default with room for exceptions, not a perfect record.

SOURCES · 1 *Clocks & Sleep* (2026) review; developmental-sleep literature (ages 6–12). Family Desk carries a standing "general guidance, not medical advice" label; consult a clinician for persistent concerns.

THE MACRO DESK · THE PORTFOLIO LENS

Long and variable lags

Milton Friedman's warning was that monetary policy works "with long and variable lags" — you steer with a wheel that answers late. This month the whole market is living that sentence: reacting now to data that measures the past, while an old anchor finally reprices.

VWRA	GLOB. BONDS	US 10Y	JGB 10Y	DXY	GOLD	BTC
\$190	flat	4.49%	2.77%	~101	\$4,170	\$61k

The regime this week is **rotation, not retreat** (advancing No. 35, not re-explaining it). June payrolls came in soft — around 57,000 against ~110,000 expected, though the unemployment rate slipped to 4.2% — and the one-year inflation swap has collapsed from a May peak near 3.5% to about 2.1%.¹ Together they have faded the July rate-hike scare that dominated late June: new Fed chair Kevin Warsh, speaking at Sintra, said "inflation risks have come down" while holding the funds rate at 3.50–3.75% and promising "a good family fight" at the July meeting.² A softer dollar (DXY back to ~101 from a 13-month high) has lifted gold off its lows to ~\$4,170 and floated bitcoin back above ~\$61k after its worst-ever month for spot ETFs.³

Notice the lag in every link of that chain. The Fed is reacting to a June labour print that describes a month already gone; the "hike scare" it is unwinding was itself built on a May CPI (4.2%) that markets now treat as backward-looking; the oil relief that will cool inflation later is already in the tape but not yet in the data. This is Friedman's point made flesh: policy and prices are always answering a question the world asked some time ago.

The fresh wrinkle — the anchor reprices. The quieter, more structural story is in Tokyo. Japan's long-end government bonds sold off hard: the 10-year JGB yield rose toward 2.77%, near a multi-decade high, and the 30-year pushed above 4.00%.⁴ For a generation, near-zero JGBs were the world's anchor of cheap money; that anchor is dragging. It is the ultimate lag — decades of ultra-loose policy repricing at last — and it matters directly to the "global bonds" half of this reader's portfolio, since a higher Japanese yield tugs at the whole global aggregate.

THE HONESTY RULE

This desk explains markets; it does not advise. Levels are dated to Thursday 2 July (US markets shut Friday 3 July for the holiday) and held honestly where unconfirmed — the June CPI print, the next real test of the lag, lands mid-month and is *awaited*, not guessed. Gold and bitcoin are tracked for macro sensitivity only; bitcoin's volatility is far higher and it is not endorsed. The reader's anchors remain VWRA and global bonds. No market level here is fabricated.

2.1%

1-YR INFLATION SWAP — DOWN FROM
~3.5% IN MAY

~4.00%

30-YR JGB — THE OLD ANCHOR,
DRAGGING

ROTATION DOLLAR-SOFT

HIKE-SCARE FADING

WHAT IT MEANS — VWRA, BONDS, GOLD & BTC

VWRA: broadening leadership (Dow, equal-weight, small-caps at records vs a wobbly Nasdaq) is healthy — you own all of it. **Global bonds:** the US leg helps as hike fears ebb; the JGB leg is the offset to watch. **Gold:** a softer dollar and lower real yields are its friends — read for sensitivity, not endorsed. **BTC:** up on the liquidity turn, but its worst-ever ETF month is the volatility reminder — a read-through, not a holding.

SOURCES · 1,3 Saxo Market Quick Take (2 Jul 2026); BlackRock weekly. 2 Warsh/Sintra remarks; No. 35 (carried). 4 Saxo (JGB long-end, 2 Jul 2026). Friedman, "long and variable lags" (monetarist doctrine). Education, not investment advice.

CURIOSITIES · ASTRONOMY

The ten-year movie begins

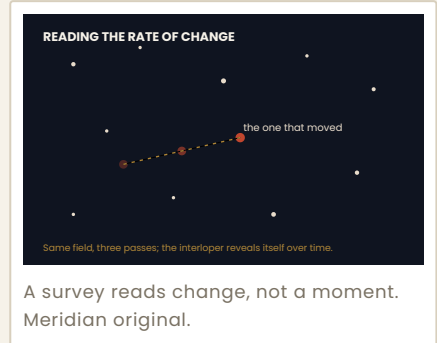
On a mountain in Chile, the Vera Rubin Observatory has started rolling the most ambitious film ever attempted: a decade-long, night-after-night recording of the entire southern sky. It is a machine built entirely around the lag between light and its arrival.

At the end of June, Rubin's Legacy Survey of Space and Time — the LSST — formally began.¹ For ten years it will photograph the whole visible southern sky every few nights, building a time-lapse of the cosmos that captures anything which moves or changes brightness: exploding stars, drifting asteroids, flickering quasars, and — the part that ties this book together — interstellar visitors like last year's 3I/ATLAS, which slipped through and left before anyone could reach it (No. 35).² Rubin is the instrument built to catch the next one early. It will log billions of objects; the challenge is no longer seeing, but keeping up with what has changed since the last pass.

An observatory is, at heart, a lag machine, and Rubin makes the point at planetary scale. Every photon it records is old news: the light from a nearby galaxy left before humans farmed; from a distant quasar, before the Sun formed. Astronomy is the one science in which seeing is always seeing-late — you cannot observe the universe as it is, only as it was when the light set out. Rubin turns that limitation into a method: by watching the same sky over and over, it reads not a moment but a *rate of change*, the one thing a single old snapshot can never give you.

Seeing is always seeing-late.

There is a discipline in that for the rest of us. The most useful picture is rarely the instant one; it is the one built from many passes, over time, until the thing that is actually moving reveals itself against the things that only seemed to.



ALSO OUT THERE

A first for TESS. NASA's planet-hunter detected a Jupiter-like world via gravitational microlensing — an Einstein trick, and a technique new to the spacecraft that could open a whole category of finds.³

Dark matter, questioned again. A University of Bonn team says new data strain the standard dark-matter picture. Flagged as contested — a challenge to a pillar, not a demolition; the consensus has survived such tests before (No. 33).⁴

A patriotic sky. For America's 250th, NASA's Chandra released four red-white-and-blue deep-space images — an exploded star, a stellar nursery, a starburst galaxy. Old light, dressed for a birthday.

SOURCES · 1–2 Universe Today (30 Jun 2026), Rubin/LSST first light; 3I/ATLAS per No. 35. 3 Universe Today (3 Jul 2026), TESS microlensing. 4 Universe Today / Univ. of Bonn (3 Jul 2026), flagged contested. Chandra: NASA (4 Jul 2026).

LOVE & LIFE · THE EXAMINED LIFE

The two kinds of alone

Last issue we looked at the friendship recession. The research has a subtler point to add: being alone is not one condition but two, and the difference between them is the one variable you can actually change.

"A lone" hides a fork. There is the solitude you choose — the quiet hour, the solo walk, the deliberate withdrawal that restores you — and there is the solitude imposed on you, the aloneness you did not pick and cannot easily end. Recent work on attachment gives the distinction teeth: people high in anxious or avoidant attachment tend to experience what researchers call "non-self-determined solitude," and it is *that* flavour — solitude without agency — that tracks most strongly with intense loneliness.¹ The same number of hours by yourself can be a balm or a wound; what decides which is whether you held the door.

This reframes last issue's friendship recession (No. 35) usefully. The problem was never solitude as such — plenty of well-connected people crave more of it. The problem is solitude that arrives unbidden and outstays its welcome, and then, on a lag, hardens into loneliness. Because that is the tempo of it: loneliness is a slow tax, not a sudden bill. A single unchosen evening is nothing; a season of them, unremarked, quietly revises how a person sees their whole social world. The cause and the ache are weeks apart, which is exactly why we mislabel the ache as a personality and not a circumstance.

The same hours by yourself can be a balm or a wound; what decides which is whether you held the door.

The practical reading is gentler than "make more friends," and more precise. The lever is agency: convert imposed solitude into chosen solitude wherever you can (make the quiet a decision, not a default), and put a few unmissable, recurring points of contact on the calendar so that connection is structural rather than willed — the standing dinner, the fixed call — the same "systems over willpower" conclusion the friendship research reached from the other side.

THE CAVEAT

This is a distinction the evidence supports, not a cure it promises — the studies are largely correlational, and "just choose your solitude" is cold comfort to someone whose aloneness is structural (a bereavement, a move, a caregiving load). The honest claim is smaller and truer: where you have any agency over your time alone, using it changes the experience of it. That is a nudge, not a fix.

SOURCES · 1 PsyPost, attachment & "non-self-determined solitude" (2026); solitude-vs-loneliness literature. Ties No. 35 (friendship recession). Reflection, not clinical guidance; persistent loneliness warrants real-world support.

FITNESS · LONGEVITY

The slowest lag of all

Everything you do for your health in your forties is a deposit you won't withdraw until your seventies. 2026's longevity research sharpens two of those deposits — one you're probably under-funding, and one you might not have known was a deposit at all.

Fitness is this issue's purest example of lag: the payoff arrives decades after the work. That is why it is so easy to under-invest — the bill for a sedentary forties comes due in a sixties you can't yet feel. A 2026 round-up of the year's longevity findings sharpens two deposits worth topping up now.¹

Protein — the number is higher than you think. The dietary reference intake of ~0.8 g per kg of bodyweight is a floor set to prevent deficiency, not a target for an active adult trying to hold muscle into later life. The emerging consensus for people training in their forties and beyond sits closer to ~1.2–1.6 g/kg per day — for many, meaningfully more than they currently eat, and the single most under-funded deposit in the average optimiser's plan. Muscle is the account you draw on when you're old; protein is how you fund it, and the funding has to happen years ahead.²

Mindset — a lever you didn't know was one. The year's most surprising finding isn't physical. A Yale study (Becca Levy, published in *Geriatrics*, 2026) tracked nearly 4,000 adults and found that those holding more positive attitudes about their own ageing were significantly more likely to *improve* — cognitively and physically — in later life.³ How you think about getting older appears to shape how you actually age. It is the longest-fuse deposit of all: a belief, held for decades, that quietly compounds.

Muscle is the account you draw on when you're old.

1.2–1.6

G PROTEIN / KG / DAY — THE ACTIVE-40S TARGET, NOT 0.8

THE SETTLED ANCHOR

Beneath the new findings, the 30-year evidence holds: *combine* strength and aerobic work. Roughly 90–120 min/week of strength *plus* regular aerobic activity was linked to about a 45% lower mortality risk — more than either alone (No. 32/34). The deposits stack; they don't substitute.⁴

LONGEVITY-DISCOURSE SCEPTIC

Handle the mindset study with care: it is observational, and "just think positively about ageing" can shade into blaming people for decline they didn't choose. Attitude is a contributor, not a controller. And protein targets are a range, not a prescription — kidney conditions and individual needs vary. General guidance, not medical advice; check with a clinician.

SOURCES · 1,3 SUCCESS, "Longevity Science 2026" & Levy et al., *Geriatrics* (2026). 2 Established sports-nutrition consensus (protein for active/older adults). 4 Zhang et al., *BJSM* (2026), 30-yr cohort; ScienceAlert. General guidance, not medical advice.

THE DIARY · SINGAPORE

The things worth putting in the calendar

School holidays wind down, the World Cup runs late, and the run-up to the nation's 61st birthday begins. What to book now, before it books up.

MARQUEE

★ = OUR PICK

- 9
AUG

★ NDP 2026 · SG61

NATIONAL STADIUM · FIRST INDOOR 300-DRONE SHOW · GUN SALUTE AT KALLANG BASIN
- 24–26
JUL

★ EXO

SG FINALE OF THE WORLD TOUR · THIRD-GEN COMEBACK · TICKETMASTER

EXHIBITIONS & THE EXAMINED WEEKEND

- to 1
NOV

Into the Ocean: Journey Beneath

ARTSCIENCE × OCEANX · SUBMERSIBLE FOOTAGE, 10 ZONES · FAMILY
- to 16
AUG

Flesh & Bones: The Art of Anatomy

ARTSCIENCE MUSEUM · 160+ ARTEFACTS · TCM & AYURVEDA LENS
- Jul
NOW

NLB Sci-Fi Pop-up Library

PARKWAY PARADE · ~4,000 SCI-FI TITLES + "FUTURE SINGAPORE: 2126" · A PKD READER'S AFTERNOON

FAMILY & OUT-OF-DOORS

- to 13
SEP

Minecraft Experience: Villager Rescue

MANDAI WILDLIFE EAST · 8 INTERACTIVE ROOMS
- Jul
SGF

Singapore Garden Festival (10th ed.)

GARDENS BY THE BAY · THE "OLYMPICS" OF LANDSCAPE DESIGN · DATES ON VISITSINGAPORE
- wknds
JUL

Sentosa GrillFest

SILOSO BEACH · 40+ STALLS, FOUR ZONES · FOUR WEEKENDS
- 11
JUL

Little Island Brewing — BBQ, Brews & Beats

CHANGI VILLAGE · FREE OUTDOOR MUSIC & COOKOUT · 11TH ANNIVERSARY

ON THE CONCERT HORIZON

- 22
AUG

Post Malone — Big Ass World Tour

ARENA @ EXPO · W/ DON TOLIVER
- 4–6
AUG

Honne (10th-anniversary)

CAPITOL THEATRE · THREE INTIMATE NIGHTS

PLANNING NOTES

NDP tickets ballot early; national-education (NE) shows 11 & 18 Jul and previews 25 Jul & 1 Aug are the easier way in, with free rehearsal-Saturday fireworks. EXO sells fast — set a Ticketmaster alert. BIGBANG (17 Oct, National Stadium) is still one line: the SG on-sale remains unannounced at press time; register via b.stage, and treat any "tickets live" post as unverified.

THE DIARY · JAPAN & THE REGION

Matsuri season, at a soft-yen discount

July is the heart of Japan's festival calendar — and with the yen near ¥160 (Good Life, p11), the flights have rarely made more sense for the traveller who plans ahead.

JAPAN — TOKYO & NATIONWIDE ★ = OUR PICK

17&24 JUL	★ Gion Matsuri KYOTO · THE YAMAHOKO FLOAT PARADES · JAPAN'S GRANDEST FESTIVAL
25 JUL	★ Sumida River Fireworks TOKYO · ~20,000 SHELLS · BOOK A ROOFTOP OR RIVERSIDE MONTHS AHEAD
24–25 JUL	Tenjin Matsuri OSAKA · LAND & RIVER PROCESSIONS, FIREWORKS FINALE
24–26 JUL	Fuji Rock Festival NAEBA · JAPAN'S MARQUEE MUSIC WEEKEND IN THE MOUNTAINS
2–7 AUG	Aomori Nebuta / Akita Kantō TŌHOKU'S GREAT SUMMER LANTERN FESTIVALS · PLAN RAIL EARLY
11–13 JUL	Naadam MONGOLIA · WRESTLING, ARCHERY, HORSE-RACING · THE REGION'S WILD CARD

THE TABLE SINGAPORE'S NEWEST, HONESTLY JUDGED

SOFT LAUNCH	VALUE	REVIVAL	TOO NEW
FreakyNoods (Chinatown) — the ice-cream shop FreakyCones' cheeky Japanese-inspired pasta spin-off, soft-launched 1 Jul: gochujang-rose "Duck Buddy" (\$16.90+) and friends. Early notices are warm but it's days old — <i>promising, still settling</i> . Affordable, walk-in.			
Yi Man Fen "Sugar Rush" (313 Somerset) — the viral China sweet-soup chain (90+ outlets) makes its first overseas stop; handcrafted grass-jelly and shaved-ice bowls ~\$5.80. <i>Hyped online, too new to call</i> . Not halal.			
Madeleine's Portuguese Egg Tarts (Aperia) — a 26-year-old egg-tart name returns after years away: the issue's culinary lag, a flavour on a two-decade delay. <i>Nostalgia, verdict pending</i> . Not halal.			
Cookboys by Han's (112 Katong) — a British-Hainanese heritage concept from Han's, nodding to the 1870s cooks of the colonial mess halls; mutton stew, fish & chips, Hokkien mee, ~\$14–24. <i>Comforting, family-friendly value</i> .			

THE BUZZ — ONE VERDICT

A rare split-personality month: two openings betting on virality (FreakyNoods, Sugar Rush) and two on memory (Madeleine's, Cookboys). "Now reviewed" watch — the **Tiffany Blue Box Cafe** (No. 35) officially opens mid-July; still pre-review, verdict genuinely out. **Hikiniku to Come** stays retired (No. 28) and is not relisted.

THE LONG READ · AN ESSAY

The Long Fuse

A war reaches a household's meter four months late. A star's light arrives before the pharaohs. A muscle built at forty-five is drawn on at seventy. The gap between a cause and its reckoning is not a flaw in the world. It is the world's basic grammar – and learning to read it is most of wisdom.

In the winter of 1676, a young Danish astronomer named Ole Rømer stood before the Académie in Paris and announced something that should have been impossible to know: that light takes time to travel. He had it from Jupiter. The great planet's innermost moon, Io, ducks behind it and re-emerges on a clockwork schedule – except that the clock seemed to run slow when Earth was on the far side of its orbit and fast when it was near. Rømer's insight was that the discrepancy was not in Io but in the distance the light had to cross to reach him. When Earth was farther, the news of each eclipse arrived later. Seeing, he realised, is never seeing *now*. It is always seeing *then*.¹

That is the discovery this whole issue keeps rediscovering in smaller keys. The Vera Rubin Observatory (Curiosities, p16), switching on its ten-year survey this month, is Rømer's principle industrialised: an instrument that treats the lag between light and its arrival not as a nuisance but as its entire method, reading the sky's *rate of change* across years because no single old photograph could ever show what is actually moving. Every science that looks outward is, at bottom, the disciplined study of old news.

But lag is not only an astronomer's problem. It is the shape of consequence itself, and it runs in two directions. Some fuses burn toward a blast; some burn toward a bloom. The art – personal, financial, civilisational – is telling which fuse you are holding, and then having the patience or the fear appropriate to it.

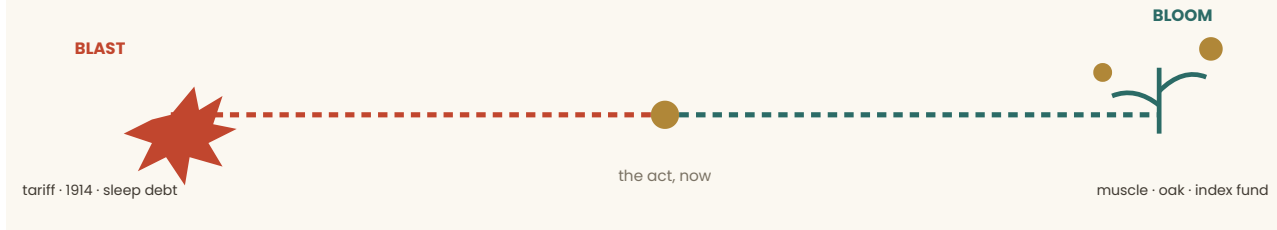
Seeing is never seeing now. It is always seeing then.

Consider the blast end first, because it is the one that hurts. This month a Singapore household opens an electricity bill 17 per cent higher than the last, and the reason is a war in a strait 8,000 kilometres away that the oil market has already forgotten (Singapore, p5). The tariff formula reaches back to gas prices from April and May – the war-inflated weeks – so the bill arrives, precisely, in arrears. The shooting stopped; the invoice did not. And the relief now visible in cheap Brent will not reach the meter until near Christmas. Cause and consequence, sitting four months apart, so that the person paying can no longer see what they are paying for.

Economists have a name for this. Milton Friedman spent a career insisting that monetary policy operates with "long and variable lags" – that a central bank pulling a lever today is steering a ship that will not turn for a year or more, using a wheel that answers late and unpredictably.² Our own Macro Desk (p15) is living the sentence this month: a Federal Reserve reacting to June's soft jobs, which describe a month already gone; a "rate-hike scare" being unwound that was built on a May inflation print markets now call backward-looking; a Japanese bond market finally repricing decades of near-zero policy, the longest lag of all coming due at once. The steering is always a conversation with the recent past.

SOURCES · 1 Rømer's 1676 determination of the finite speed of light from the eclipses of Io (Académie des Sciences). 2 Milton Friedman, monetarist doctrine of "long and variable lags" (e.g. *A Program for Monetary Stability*, 1960).

TWO ENDS OF THE SAME FUSE



The same delay, two destinations. Meridian original.

The blast end has a darker archive than a power bill. Historians of the First World War borrowed a phrase for how it began: *the long fuse*.¹ A single act on 28 June 1914 — an assassination in Sarajevo — lit something that did not detonate for weeks, burning quietly through a lattice of alliances, mobilisation timetables and wounded pride until, in early August, a continent was at war. Nobody who lit it in June intended August. That is the terror of a long fuse: the interval between the spark and the fire is long enough that the people responsible can convince themselves nothing has happened, right up until everything has. It is worth holding in mind as we watch a 60-day diplomatic clock tick over the Gulf (The World, p3), its hardest questions deferred rather than answered. Deferral is not defusing. A fuse you have merely stopped watching is still burning.

And yet — and this is the turn the epigraph insists on — the lag is not the enemy. "Though the mills of God grind slowly," runs Longfellow's old couplet, "yet they grind exceeding small." Slow *and* exact: the delay is not sloppiness but process. The same interval that lets a catastrophe assemble unseen is the interval in which every good and patient thing is built. Turn the fuse around, and it burns toward a bloom.

There is a proverb, usually called Greek, that a society grows great when old men plant trees in whose shade they know they shall never sit. The English tell a version about New College, Oxford,

whose great hall was roofed in oak: when, centuries on, the beams needed replacing, the college is said to have found that its founder had planted an oak grove for exactly this day — a five-hundred-year gift, posted forward in time. The story is probably embellished in the retelling.² It survives anyway because it names something true: the highest form of sanity is to act for a reckoning you will not personally collect.

Deferral is not defusing. A fuse you have merely stopped watching is still burning.

This reader knows the bloom end intimately, because his whole financial life is built on it. The index fund he holds (Macro, p15) is a machine for the patient fuse — Jack Bogle's 1976 "folly," mocked at launch, now the default way the world saves, a structure that pays precisely because its owner does nothing while it compounds (a callback to No. 34's "gradually, then suddenly," read in the happy direction). The muscle the Fitness Desk (p18) begs him to bank at forty-five is the same trade in flesh: a deposit whose withdrawal is thirty years out. Even the small objects in this issue argue it — a headphone with a battery you can replace (p9), a tube amplifier that only sounds right once it has warmed (p11). Each is a tiny wager that patience will be rewarded on a delay.

SOURCES • 1 Laurence Lafore, *The Long Fuse* (1965), on the origins of the First World War; the July Crisis (28 Jun–early Aug 1914). 2 The New College, Oxford oak-beam story — widely retold (Stewart Brand / Gregory Bateson), and generally regarded as embellished; the Greek "plant trees" proverb, attribution uncertain.

So the discipline the whole issue keeps circling is a single one, worn on both faces of the coin. **Read which fuse you are holding.** When the delay leads to a blast — an unwatched conflict, a compounding sleep debt in a child (Family, p13), a leverage you have talked yourself into ignoring — the lag is a danger, and the only defence is to act *before* the interval fools you into thinking there is no interval. You cannot un-write July's electricity bill; you can, however, refuse to be surprised by it, and arrange your life so the next one lands softer.

And when the delay leads to a bloom — the funded muscle, the planted oak, the fed index, the warmed valve, the child whose steady sleep this fortnight pays out in a steadier September — the lag is not to be endured but *trusted*. Its whole nature is that most of the return arrives on the days when nothing seems to be happening. The temptation, always, is to stop feeding the slow thing because it has not yet flowered. That is precisely the mistake the structure is designed to punish. Bogle's fortune, and the reader's, is made on the boring Tuesdays.

Most of the return arrives on the days when nothing seems to be happening.

There is a consolation in the epigraph's second clause that is easy to miss. The mills grind slowly —

yes, the reckoning keeps you waiting. But they grind *exceeding small*: the reckoning, when it comes, is exact. That exactness is everywhere in this book. It is the electricity tariff, computed to the cent from a fixed window of gas prices. It is the CPI print the Macro Desk awaits, which will measure a past month to a decimal. It is the light-clock of *Io* that let Rømer weigh the speed of light from a few minutes' discrepancy in a moon's schedule. The universe keeps precise books; it simply settles them late. Which means the lag is not an excuse to look away. It is a reason to act as though the invoice — or the harvest — is already, exactly, being tallied. Because it is.

Bashō, our last issue's companion, wrote that the journey itself is home. He might have added that the journey is also a fuse: every step a small deferral, laying down a self that some later self will have to live inside. We spend so much attention on the moment of arrival — the print, the verdict, the opening night — and so little on the long, quiet burning in between, where the outcome is actually decided. The wise move is to mind the fuse, not the flash. Light it well, or don't light it at all; then feed the slow, good things, and wait, with the patience of someone who knows that slowly is not the same as never — and that exceeding small is not the same as wrong.

— The Editors, *Meridian* No. 36

A note on the strip we run each issue. The market levels on page two are dated to a Thursday — because on the Friday, America closed to mark two hundred and fifty years. Even the tape observes a lag: it recorded, then rested, then will reckon on Monday. There is something fitting in a briefing about delay going to press across a holiday, the numbers frozen mid-breath. By the time you read this, the world will already have moved. It always has. The trick, as the mills remind us, is that it moves slowly, and exactly, and never quite when you are looking.

CONSOLIDATED SOURCES — NO. 36

The World: CNN, Al Jazeera, CBS, NBC, PBS, Wikipedia (Iran–US, 1 Jul); ESPN/NBC/Yahoo (World Cup).

Singapore: SP Group/EMA tariff notice (30 Jun); MOF U-Save; Sunollo; SGX/TradingView; MTI/SingStat.

Property: Stackedhomes/URA GLS (3 Jul); 99.co (June BTO); PropertyGuru.

Technology: Bloomberg, CNBC, The AI Chronicle (SK hynix); NVIDIA; Motley Fool; Manufacturing Dive; open-LLM leaderboards.

Kit / Good Life: What Hi-Fi?, Gear Patrol, BGR; Astell&Kern; Sennheiser; Xreal.

Connected Home: Home Assistant 2026.7 notes.

Screen & Sound: Billboard, EntertainmentNow, InMusic, Ultimate Classic Rock; Screen Rant, Box Office Pro, Deadline.

Family: *Clocks & Sleep* (2026); social-jetlag literature.

Macro: Saxo, BlackRock; Warsh/Sintra; Friedman (lags).

Curiosities: Universe Today (Rubin/LSST, TESS, Bonn); NASA/Chandra.

Love & Life: PsyPost (solitude & attachment).

Fitness: SUCCESS; Levy, *Geriatrics* (2026); Zhang, *BJSM* (2026).

Diary / Table: VisitSingapore, Time Out, SETHLUI, Eatbook, HungryGoWhere; JNTO.

Long Read: Romer (1676); Friedman; Lafore, *The Long Fuse* (1965); Bogle (1976); Longfellow/von Logau.